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**AIR lands \$23M to bring
its eVTOLs to the US**



The combined forces of escalating geopolitical tensions and rising defense budgets are spurring many electric vertical takeoff and landing (eVTOL) makers to take a two-pronged approach to building their aircraft: crewed vehicles for personal or commercial taxi use, and uncrewed vehicles meant for logistics and defense purposes.

AIR, an Israel-based startup developing eVTOLs, thought it prudent to adopt a similar approach from the get-go, designing both its uncrewed and piloted aircraft with the same airframe and core systems so it could develop for both use cases at once.

The company currently offers a piloted eVTOL craft, dubbed AIR ONE, for personal use, and an uncrewed eVTOL designed for cargo transport, contested logistics, and defense applications. Since its first cargo eVTOL delivery in late 2023, the company has secured over 2,500 preorders for its piloted personal aircraft, AIR ONE, and plans to ship 15 cargo eVTOLs this year.

To build on that momentum, AIR recently raised \$23 million in a Series A funding round led by Entrée Capital, with participation from existing backer Dr. Shmuel Harlap, an early investor in Mobileye. The new capital will be used to scale its production facility in Israel, hire additional employees, and support the company's expansion to the U.S., CEO and co-founder Rani Plaut told TechCrunch in an interview.

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The Series A funding comes in the wake of [a recent U.S. executive order](#) promoting domestic drone and eVTOL development, as well as [an update to the FAA's MOSAIC rule](#) that expands certification pathways.

The company's cargo aircraft currently in operation do not require full Type certification and are flown under [Experimental Airworthiness Certificates](#) (EAC) for logistics and dual-use missions, according to Plaut. EACs are issued to aircraft that are in development, testing, or for research purposes. They allow the aircraft to fly under strict conditions and limitations.

"Our launch customer is flying under an Experimental Airworthiness Certificate, which will convert to [a "Type" certificate](#) once the uncrewed eVTOL completes the certification process," he said.

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Type certification means an aircraft meets all applicable safety and regulatory standards, and

can be produced and operated commercially. EACs don't "convert" automatically to Type certificates; AIR likely will use its EAC to test its prototype while working through the Type certification process.

Meanwhile, AIR expects the two-seated, piloted AIR ONE to qualify for [Light Sport Aircraft \(LSA\)](#) certification under the new MOSAIC rules. Aircraft certified as LSA are limited to flying outside densely populated areas and away from controlled airspace.

"We designed the AIR ONE from day one to align with the MOSAIC LSA criteria, anticipating a more streamlined certification pathway," Plaut added. "Now that the rule is finalized, we're on track to become the first piloted eVTOL certified under LSA to reach private customers. Our goal is to begin deliveries as soon as the rule becomes enforceable in 2026."

The U.S. is a great market for eVTOL companies today, given the opportunity to land enterprise and government contracts, especially as the Trump administration adopts an increasingly hawkish defense stance. But AIR will face intense competition: [Joby Aviation](#) and [Archer Aviation](#) already have [partnerships with airlines](#) to bring their air taxi services to life, and, along with Beta Technologies, they already have [military contracts](#) for testing their aircrafts' recon and logistics abilities. On top of that, AIR isn't manufacturing its eVTOLs in the U.S. yet, which is table stakes for winning government contracts.

Still, AIR says its design architecture and cost control give it an edge against the incumbents. It hopes its current funding round will help it with its planned U.S.-based manufacturing hub for high-volume production.

“What sets AIR apart is the shared design DNA between both aircraft variants,” Plaut said. This unified architecture allows for cross-platform upgrades, meaning advancements in one model can be applied to the other, streamlining development, manufacturing, and scalability, he explained.

“The size and folding-wing mechanism solve a major infrastructure hurdle,” Plaut explained. “They don’t require airports or complex handling — just a flat surface — and can park in most garages or driveways.”

AIR’s uncrewed model also follows simplified SOPs (standard operating procedures), which, the CEO says, allows even minimally trained ground crews to operate it. “And we’re closing the cost gap by applying automotive-grade manufacturing principles for scalable production,” he added.

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IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY AVIATION

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Joby Aviation accelerates path to market with \$55M DoD contract

Rebecca Bellan — 7:00 AM PDT · April 26, 2023

Electric vertical takeoff and landing (eVTOL) company Joby Aviation's strategy for launching commercially in 2025 is becoming more clear.

The startup secured a \$55 million contract from the U.S. Department of Defense Tuesday, a deal that will allow the company to put its aircraft into

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[In November](#), the FAA issued airworthiness criteria for Joby to certify its Model JAS4-1 aircraft to operate in U.S. airspace. The company had also previously received airworthiness approval from the Air Force for an uncrewed electric aircraft in 2020.

When it comes to Joby's other path to commercialization — which is similar to a rideshare app where customers pay to be transported via Joby's air taxis — the company is chipping away at its FAA requirements. [In February](#), Joby began final assembly on its company-conforming eVTOL, which is a prototype that's a couple steps away from the final version.

The company also completed the second stage of a process with the FAA to achieve type certification. Joby still has a few more stages in that process before it can move onto production certification, which will allow the company to mass-produce its eVTOLs.

There's a lot of overlap between the two paths to certification. Paul Sciarra, Joby executive chairman, says the value of that is twofold.

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“One is that we get to basically put product into the hands of customers a lot more quickly, generate revenue more quickly, but then also gain the learnings of what it takes to operate these aircraft, what it takes to train pilots, what it takes to dispatch the vehicles,” Sciarra told TechCrunch. “And we do that in a smaller, more controlled setting before bringing it to the broader consumer side.”

The latest injection of capital from the DoD marks Joby's [third extension of its Agility Prime contract](#) with the U.S. Air Force, an initiative launched in April 2020 to test, experiment and accelerate the development of eVTOL for cross commercial and military use. This week's contract brings the total potential value of Joby's current contract up to \$131 million, according to the company.

As part of the agreement, Joby will deliver and operate up to nine of its five-seat, low-noise electric aircraft, the first two of which are expected to be delivered to Edwards Air Force Base in California by spring 2024. Joby's eVTOLs will be used to demonstrate logistics use cases, like transporting people and cargo, as well as potentially medical evacuations.

Joby will retain ownership of the aircraft, while providing military pilots with flight training. The training sessions have already commenced at

Joby's manufacturing facility in Marina, California. Earlier this month, four pilots became the first Air Force personnel to fly Joby's eVTOL through the full flight envelope, including transition from vertical to wingborne flight. The flights were piloted remotely from the ground, and the pilots were trained in a combination of classroom-based and simulator training, the company said.

"This next step of getting Air Force pilots trained and operating Joby aircraft at an Air Force installation is an incredibly important milestone for the program, providing key insights to actual operations and use case validation for Advanced Air Mobility aircraft," said Lt. Col. Tom Meagher, division lead of Agility Prime, in a statement. "Additionally, the Joby operations provide an outstanding opportunity for accelerated learning with the other Department of Defense services and government agencies, including NASA and the FAA."

Sciarra said Joby's initial deployment is hopefully the first stage of even larger contracts with different government agencies over time.

The air taxi market prepares to take flight



Electric air mobility is gaining elevation. But there's going to be some turbulence ahead.



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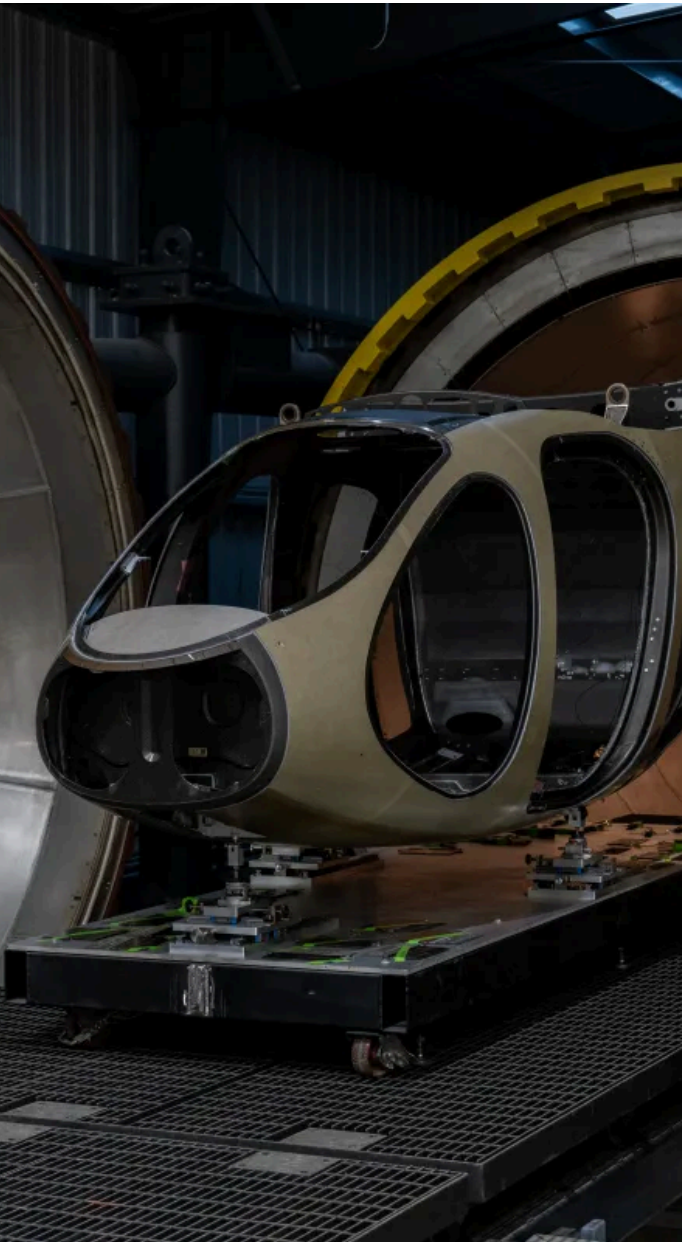


IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY AVIATION

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Joby flies towards 2025 commercial launch with final assembly of eVTOL

Rebecca Bellan — 5:00 AM PST · February 14, 2023

Electric vertical takeoff and landing (eVTOL) company Joby Aviation has taken another step on

its path to start a commercial air taxi service by 2025. The company said Tuesday that it's begun final assembly on its "company-conforming" eVTOL, which is essentially a prototype that's a couple steps away from the final version.

Joby expects to begin flight testing for the aircraft in the first half of this year.

The technological milestone comes a week after [Joby completed the second stage](#) of a process with the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) to achieve type certification for its aircraft for commercial passenger use. Joby says it's making moves on the final three stages of that process, as well.

Type certification would mean the FAA approves Joby's aircraft design and all component parts. It also signifies the design is compliant with the agency's standards for airworthiness and noise. After that, Joby will need to achieve production certification, which will allow Joby to mass produce its eVTOLs under the FAA-approved designs.

In getting to the point of final assembly, Joby had to put in place an intense quality management system that includes tracking and documenting every part on the aircraft, design drawings used to manufacture aircraft components, environmental conditions during fabrications and actions taken by manufacturing technicians.

Didier Papadopoulos, head of aircraft OEM at Joby, said the steps Joby has taken to produce a company-conforming aircraft, including the quality management system and regular FAA reviews, brings the company closer to receiving its production certification.

Joby has already built the major structures of the aircraft, like the wing, tail and fuselage, and will

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now fuse everything together and install wiring, electronics, actuation and propulsion systems.



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The aircraft will be the first one produced at Joby's pilot manufacturing facility in Marina, California. That facility is designed to prove out Joby's manufacturing process through low-rate manufacturing and is capable of producing tens of aircraft per year, according to the company. Joby is already using the facility to build and assemble parts for future aircraft.

When it comes to more scaled manufacturing, Joby is currently in the market for a location for its Phase 1 production facility. The company says it's actively reviewing proposals from a number of states keen to boost manufacturing and create jobs.

Joby Aviation secures certificate to operate commercial air taxis



Joby Aviation — the publicly traded electric air vehicle company with a current market cap of \$3.1 billion — has received the necessary certification from the Federal Aviation Administration to begin on-demand commercial air taxi operations, the company said on Thursday. While it's a significant milestone that puts Joby closer to its stated goal of ... [Continue reading](#)

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